

# Synthetic Arguments

August 21, 2026

# Collective Action

- Ziblatt 2017: can the elites solve a collective action problem in facilitating a transition to a coherent conservative political movement?
- Stigler & Becker 1990: norms can support otherwise-irrational behavior particularly because gathering the information to deviate to a new behavior away from the norm is costly
- Taylor 1990: definition satisfied when “rational individual action can lead to a strictly Pareto-inferior outcome.” Solutions can be internal (no changing of structure) or external (changing of structure)
  - Potential external solutions: political entrepreneur as coordination, stronger property rights to emphasize individualism and internalize utilities, and norms – *when there is sufficient consequence to deviating from them*
- Coleman 1990: norms emerge as outcomes / solutions from repeated PD problems
- Miller 1990: norms of cooperation solve collective action problems, but must be supported and maintained, preferably through behavioral influence and cultural adaptation rather than institutional systems
- Hardin 1990: Perverse logic of state construction: if we construct the state to enforce collective action solutions, then we must overcome the collective action problem of constructing the state itself
- Obviously all of Olson 1965 – existence, group size as deterministic, privileged groups vs. latent (non-privileged) groups. Need selective incentives to overcome
  - Also note – “exploitation of the great by the small” – largest stakeholders tend to contribute disproportionately as they have the most to lose by nonappropriation
- Ostrom 1965: tragedy of the commons exists when there is no institutional environment to “solve” it – but, it can in fact be solved by effective institutional design
- Putnam 1993: democratic governance is in part a trust equilibrium. Order without coercion requires all players expecting that everyone will follow the rules of that society
- Scott 1985: a great deal of political resistance takes place outside of collective action solutions, as individually-rationalizable efforts are much easier to support in equilibrium (and appear throughout peasant classes)
- Svoboda 2012: authoritarian politics creates a collective action problem whereby efforts to seize / undermine power must be undertaken by a group, but failure will result in a high cost
- Acemoglu & Robinson: lower opportunity costs makes collective action w.r.t. revolution more viable

- Diermeier & Vlaicu 2011: collective action problem exists if predicted behavior does not outcome (ish)
- Sandler 1992: a review of the quarter century following Olson’s logic. Shows that collective action can sometimes occur absent formal institutions, and claims that the non-examples have been part of the general intrigue of Olson’s work (methodological consideration about non-examples below)
- Shepsle & Bonchuck 1997 – Comparison of the modern world as a much lighter version of the Leviathan; claims that both historically and contemporarily, there are overwhelming examples of noncooperation rather than cooperation. But, claims a third alternative (to either full cooperation or the Leviathan): “Cooperation may emerge and be maintained, even though people have not internalized pacific or otherwise touchy-feely attitudes, and even though there is not the heavy sword of LEviathan hanging over them. This is no conjurer’s trick; it is ruthless self-interest at work.’
- Milgrom et al law merchant – the law merchant seeks to solve a commitment problem, but in its existence it must also solve a free-riding problem by making its services private/selective
- Boix 1993: authoritarianism can only be peaceful/sustainable if the poor are demobilized, such that they do not overcome the collective action problem at hand

## Development of Democracy

- Democracy as *contestation*: there exists broad inclusion and a legitimate opposition with a legitimate chance of gaining power
  - Dahl 1972: Democratization and development of the opposition are separate. Two dimensions: public contestation within politics, and the right to participate within politics. High contestation and high inclusiveness leads to polyarchy; other combinations are lesser
  - Double-transition rule: a nation is considered a developed democracy when rule transitions  $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow A$
  - Dahl 1972: in the absence of any conflict, it is difficult to retain legitimate competition
- Expansion of the franchise:
  - Acemoglu & Robinson 2000 – the west extended the franchise as a credible commitment mechanism to “buy off” commoners
    - \* Boix 2003: Less of a future commitment and more of an ex-ante benefit – that toleration is less costly to the elites than repression, depending on asset mobility and inequality

- North & Weingast 1989 – expansion of property rights in 18th century England as a means of commitment against exploitation and to secure public investment / credit
- Dahl 1972: three paths to polyarchy, (1) liberalization before inclusiveness, (2) inclusiveness before liberalization, (3) sudden shock (often unstable). Central question: do you make a hegemonic democracy first, or do you expand inclusion but retain authoritarianism under that broader franchise? Less common on the second one
- Expansion of the franchise – intentionally or unintentionally – requires additional institutional development:
  - Dahl 1972: Candidates and parties change as the franchise expands, in an effort to better achieve their electoral goals. Often results in new parties or party change (see Muller 1997 for a more comprehensive discussion of parties changing)
  - Huntington 1968: without sufficient political development to keep up with economic development – which itself will bring greater inclusivity – we should expect discontent and instability
  - Ziblatt 2017: If this development does not allow for conservative parties to be meaningfully included in government, then the transition to democracy is likely to be unstable and short-term
- Levy 2006 – transition of the goals of the democratic state away from market-steering to market-supporting
  - Iversen & Soskice 2019: capitalism has fueled democracy, and democracy has further consolidated because of the impacts of globalization and modern development
- Przeworski et al 2000: Development is more broadly seen in democracies precisely because economic hardship leads to democracies failing (but not autocracies): it is a selection effect, rather than a distinct causal mechanism. Democracies are less resilient to economic shocks and therefore those which survive are those with stronger economic outcomes
- Putnam 1993: democracy is facilitated by social capital and effective civil society. Without appropriate trust (“soft institutions”), states must turn towards coercion. Social capital facilitates investment, rotating credit associations, and generally more effective democratic engagement
- Boix 1999: majoritarianism vs PR is largely tied to efforts to protect the establishment parties from rising socialist movements. Average effective threshold for entry has significantly decreased in advanced democracies over the past century
  - Four factors of political transformation: (1) extension of universal suffrage; (2) introduction of competitive elections, (3) massive realignment of the party system; (4) high turnover in party organizations

- Ahmed & Stasavage 2020: Council governance (human progression away from total executive authority) often arose as a means of overcoming informational asymmetries: the leader could not sufficiently know how best to extract from their entire society, and needed some degree of representation in order to best accomplish this
- Bartels & Kramon 2020: differentiation between judicial power and institutional legitimacy

## Historical Prerequisites for Democracy

- How agrarian classes developed:
  - Dahl 1972: Farming societies differentiated into peasantry (hegemony) or free farmers (polyarchy)
- Ziblatt 2017: whether or not the elites were able to organize into a coherent political party/structure that was meaningfully involved in the democratic process, such that their interests could still be represented to some extent
- Huntington 1968 “Green uprising”: alliance of some sectors of rural and urban populations (see: workers/labour) that overcomes tensions between urbanites and rural elites and allows for stability
  - Also Huntington: “A society is vulnerable to revolution only when the opposition of the middle class to the political system coincides with the opposition of the peasants. Once the middle class becomes conservative, rural rebellion is still possible, but revolution is not.”
  - Boix 2003: Middle class will support democracy if their income is below the average (net recipients of redistribution) but not if their income is above the average (net providers of redistribution)
- Moore 1966: development of commercial agriculture drives a liberal society – instigates private markets and requires new institutions (tie to Huntington)
- Moore 1966: Democracy requires a bourgeois. If the aristocracy was dependent on the market rather than the state, they would be better entrenched in the economy and more likely to secure enfranchisement. But, if peasant class is powerful, more likely for violent revolution. **“No bourgeoisie, no democracy.”**
- Putnam 1993: historical roots of social capital, trust, and civic engagement. Northern Italy had such community capacity while Southern Italy did not (more rule by La Cosa Nostra, etc.), traces all the way back to Medieval times
  - Some ties to Selznick on this – institutions need to fit in to existing community structures with enough social capital to facilitate meaningful investment
- Lipset 1959: Definition of democracy, importance of legitimate opposition

## Nation-building & Nationality

- Four primary factors in whether an individual adopts new political beliefs: exposure, prestige, consistency w/ beliefs, consistency w/ experience **CITE**
- Cross-cutting cleavages:
  - threaten polyarchy (Dahl 1972)
- Kalyvas 2006. Nationality less influential to the outcomes of violence in civil war than would be otherwise believed, particularly given the often abstract construction of identity cleavages during war (tie to Anderson 1983?).
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: in order for a cleavage to become politically consequential, it must have (1) empirical basis, (2) normative element, and (3) organizational expression
  - Cleavages can be reinforcing (creating more distinct but severe polarization) or cross-cutting (creating party fragmentation and cross-pressurization)
- Fearon & Laitin 2003: Prevalence of civil war is not meaningfully tied to the degree of ethnic or religious diversity, when controlling for income – as wealth develops and inequality grows, then diversity may be tied to conflict
  - Key factor for prevalence of violence appears to be conditions for insurgency, such that small-scale guerilla warfare can be effective in rural areas. Rebel group must be small enough to hide
  - Similar to above – Posner 2004: identity cleavages are not sufficient *on their own* to result in intragroup violence; some other contributing factor must be involved. Most important additional concern is group size: can the groups be politically salient on their own, or is peaceful coexistence required? Can also tie to Lipset & Rokkan: what makes a cleavage politically important?
- Penn 2008: Salience of ethnic identification can largely be tied to institutional explanations. “A national identity can always be induced by equalizing wealth across groups and uniformly increasing the wealth of the state as a whole.”

## Regime Transitions

- Ziblatt 2017: enduring stability of a democratic transition requires an organized conservative movement such that the elites are not existentially threatened
- Huntington 1968: regime transition as a byproduct of institutional development (that is, the type of regime changes)
- Huntington 1968 on Modernization: replacement of esoteric authority with legitimate justifications; rise of new goals and institutions to fulfill those goals; expansion of political participation
- Levy 2006 – a little bit of a different lens, but change in the focus of democratic regimes

- Weber: tripartite authority – charismatic, traditional, and rational-legal. Huntington suggests that with modernization comes a transition away from traditional authority, and claims that the transition is to rational-legal – but, couldn't it be the case that this transition is to charismatic as well? (i.e., Napoleon).
  - Bartels & Kramon 2020: Differentiation between judicial power and institutional legitimacy; must be some degree of public support here (note: it seems implausible that any degree of charismatic legitimacy is effective for judicial legitimacy)
- Moore 1966: If peasant class is strong, regime transition to democracy is more likely to be violent rather than progressive. (This follows from a Huntington reasoning – significant expansion in political involvement / economic development without a matching expansion in political institutionalization)
- Nalepa 2010 – illustration and decisions of whether or not to expose pre-regime transgressions
- Scott 1985 – peasant resistance to regime change may often be at the informal, unorganized level of “everyday” actions
- Stokes et al 2013 – could discuss national identities with respect to patronage systems
- Acemoglu & Robinson 2001: The wealthy are faced with a threat of revolution/unrest and are the driving decision-makers in whether or not to allow for peaceful democratization or take the chances of violence. Democratization more likely via revolution if the poor have little to lose or if inequality is high (same mechanism)
  - Acemoglu & Robinson 2000 (why the west extended the franchise) – democratization as a means of commitment. Elites extended the franchise to provide a credible threat to the aristocracy/ people against future abuse of power, essentially by buying them into the democratic system
- Clark et al 2017: dissent post-transition can result in either Exit, Voice, or Loyalty; it is the actor's credible threat of departure that facilitates concessions from the central body. (That is, good government / meaningful democracy is largely driven by the citizen's credible threat of leaving, which instead facilitates them to use voice)
- Weber 1922: Charismatic authority is not stable, and long-term order requires a transition to either political-rational or traditional legitimation

## Backsliding/Populism

- Ziblatt 2017: the rise of populist movements is antithetical to the democratic need for an organized conservative movement and can subsequently lead to instability or backsliding
- Could use Huber & Shipan 2002 to talk briefly about regulatory / bureaucratic capture, although it is more of an example of how to *avoid* these outcomes via institutional design

- Przeworski et al 2000: democracy is “a system in which parties lose elections” – falling from democracy could include violations of any of the following: (1) ex-ante uncertainty about who will win; (2) ex-post irreversibility about the winner gaining office; (3) repeatability such that the winner will not change electoral rules to guarantee future wins
  - Przeworski et al 2000: “A myopic public has to be protected from itself; economic reforms must be carried out before the people have time to react.”
- Bansak, Bechtel, & Margalit 2021: Austerity packages must be highly-targeted and carefully constructed in order to minimize political risk (can further tie to pork spending and other inefficiencies)

## International Influences

- Dahl 1972: Foreign influences can directly impose institutions, affect beliefs, or affect decision sets
- Gourevitch 1978: foreign politics have significant impacts on domestic structures BEYOND just the invasion effect
  - Two primary forces on domestic politics: war (distribution of power) and trade (distribution of economic activity)
- Mansfield, Milner, & Rosendorff 2000: democracies enjoy significantly more free international trade

## Party Politics

- Parties develop as coordination mechanisms to facilitate generally-common individual behaviors into tangible political action
- Cox 1997: The number of relevant parties or candidates we should expect is a function of both the number of relevant cleavages seeking representation and the permissiveness of electoral institutions to allow for such representation. Should expect  $M + 1$  relevant competitors where  $M$  is district magnitude / number of seats available; Duverger is just this with  $M = 1$ 
  - See Posner 2004 for why some cleavages are politically salient but others are not
  - See Fearon & Laitin 2003 for why some cleavages result in violence/instability but others do not
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: contemporary parties result from cleavages in the national revolution and industrial revolution; largely frozen in target identity groups since then
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: for a movement to become a party, it must cross (1) legitimization, (2) incorporation, (3) representation, and (4) a plausible chance of achieving a



position in government

- Muller & Strom 1999: Evaluate parties as three actors – elected officials, party leadership, and on-the-ground party members
  - Parties seek to maximize either policy preferences, elected office, or votes received (but these are not complementary goals) – Muller & Strom 1999
  - Strom 1990: framework for goals between policy, office, and votes; there exists some “weighting” of these goals by each party
  - Harmel & Janda 1994: an additional goal is “democracy-seeking” where parties want to appropriately reflect democratic institutions and practices, even at the extent of other goals. (Is this potentially reflective of DSA?)
- Stokes et al 2013: parties employ brokers to solve informational problems in connecting with individual/local voters. Muller suggests that these brokers may not be as present in the wake of mass parties
- Diermeier & Vlaicu 2011: if a group of sufficiently ideologically aligned legislators exists such that the value of the collective action defect is significantly lesser, then party organization is less necessary as the behaviors will occur in equilibrium anyways
- Jones & Hwang 2005 – if parties have control over legislative futures, then we should expect to see significant degrees of falling in line, rather than pork spending etc.
- Harmel & Janda 1994 – change in party makeup and goals.
- Katz & Mair 1995: Emergence of cartel parties where colluding parties essentially coopt the state. Mass parties are just one cross-sectional view of this process. In cartel parties, the party acts as a broker between the state and civil society as it becomes more intertwined with the state
- Müller 1997: shift in party engagement/communication from direct party structures to surveys/mass media, as technology developed and it became clear that campaigning towards existing supporters was inefficient
- Heller & Mershon a la Clark et al EVL – party representatives may leave their parties. MPs are less likely to switch parties if party labels are clear and distinguishable by voters... If parties are less clearly ideologically defined, then we should expect to see more switching

## Causal Endogeneity

- Single biggest example of endogeneity probably comes down to whether development drives democracy or democracy drives development. A series of different arguments:
  - Democracy drives economic development:

- \* North & Weingast 1989: protection of property rights leads to investment of capital which in turn leads to economic development
- \* North 1990: it is the development of meaningful political institutions which leads to economic growth (more generally)
- Economic development drives democracy:
  - \* Ziblatt 2017 – the development of a well-organized conservative elite (alongside the middle class, or some portion therein) is crucial to allowing a democratic system to both emerge and be sustained
    - Boix 1993: Middle class regime preference depends on whether they are above or below the average income (such that redistribution will be either towards or away from them)
  - \* Moore 1966
  - \* Ostrom 1990: institutions emerge to solve CPR problems which arise from resource endowments or economic development
  - \* Boix 1993: Economic development leads to more mobile capital; more mobile capital reduces the coercive capacity of the state and reduces the frictions of redistributive actions
- Both
  - \* Iversen & Soskice 2019: democracy drives capitalistic tendencies, and capitalistic features drive democracy (particularly when the median voter has a vested interest in the development of national capital)
  - \* Putnam 1993: social capital drives democratic development – this development leads to better economic development, but social capital itself may be stronger in settings where economic wellbeing is present or improving
- Neither
  - \* Huntington 1968: political development does not inherently occur when economic development occurs; rather, it must be imposed or risk significant instability. (That being said, this development can be an influence on the decision to impose such institutions.)
  - \* Przeworski et al 2000: democracies are less likely to survive stagnant economies, so the democracies we observe tend to be economically developed as a survivorship effect rather than a true causal effect
- Weber 1904: no simple causal pathway between protestantism and capitalist development, but rather, mutually-compatible and complementary conditions

# Empirical Logic & Evaluation

- Huber & Shipman 2002: use the institutional environment as a separate variable rather than a fixed component of situational context
- Elster 1990: Theories can fail to explain through either indeterminacy and inadequacy, the second being more troubling. It is not inherently discrediting for a theory to be indeterminate, however – it may be useful to exclude certain possibilities or mechanisms
  - Mill 1843: value of methodological inquiry can often be to exclude non-factors and identify remaining possibilities
- Mill 1843's approaches to inquiry
  - Lipset 1959: criticizes the excessive use of singular deviant cases to disprove overarching hypotheses or theories
- North 1990a & North & Weingast 1989 – Historical PE allows us to examine long-term economic and democratic performance as institutions change, and still retains applicability of conclusions to modern politics
  - Ziblatt 2017: need to evaluate democratic performance over an extended period of time, as there exists quite a bit of intertemporal variation and instability that can provide improper indications
- Przeworski et al 2000 – because the world is not generated randomly, analysis requires a focus on counterfactuals: “To evaluate institutions, to assess their impact, we must ask what the outcomes would have been if other institutions had been observed under the same conditions.”
  - Also Przeworski et al – regimes should be classified as either dictatorship or democracy, rather than on some sort of continuous or gradient scale (makes it easy to conflate different dimensions). Svobik (2012) agrees: first consider dictatorship as a binary, then evaluate a degree
- Natural Experiments:
  - Putnam 1993: creation of new regional commissions
  - Scott 1985: development of double-cropping in Malaysian rice
  - Nalepa 2010 ish: fall of Communism
  - Huber & Shipan: Michigan medicare reform
  - Posner 2004: ethnic group sizes using post-colonial borders as exogenous/random
- Boix 1993: both purely-institutional and purely-esoteric reasoning fail to explain democratic development; instead, must include both cultural and institutional concerns

# Rationality & Limits

General thoughts:

- Kalyvas 2006 as an example of applied rationality to collective identities, though possible that this is an overextension of rational choice as it requires collapsing humanistic tendencies into measurable incentives. (However, could also see it as a monumental success within this effort to apply rationality to identity)
- Cook & Levi 1990: “The descriptive approach to rational choice focuses on the patterns of observable choices” – *then* makes the assumption that these choices are rooted in rationality
- Elster 1990: even if rational choice theory does not always produce the best or most accurate answer, equilibria conclusions may help guide our search for particular answers, behaviors, or mechanisms. However, its tendency to produce multiple equilibria with relative difficulty deciding between them is less than ideal
  - “Rational choice theory is first and foremost normative. It tells us what we ought to do in order to achieve our aims as well as possible.”
  - Broader commentary outside of Elster – perhaps the most useful application of RCT is comparative statics, that even if we cannot predict an outcome, we can reasonably predict how an outcome might change as some input changes
- Elster 1990: Three optimization operations of rational choice. Optimal actions given beliefs, optimal beliefs given information, optimal information given desires/priors
- Elster 1990: “Rationality is presupposed by any competing theory of motivation, whereas rationality itself does not presuppose anything else. On grounds of parsimony, therefore, we should begin by assuming nothing but rationality.”
- Social norms can be seemingly irrational, but it is perhaps following them which produces rationality
- Tversky & Kahneman 1990: rational predictions diverge prohibitively from behavioral outcomes; largely a result of psychological violations of VNM assumptions. Perhaps the largest one is framing, whereby “invariance” is violated – the same piece of information presented two different ways tends to yield vastly different behavioral outcomes
- Machina 1990: behavior seems to be inconsistent with rational expectations under uncertainty, but provides some structural relief to Tversky & Kahneman and suggests that “generalized expected utility” may still be a functional contribution
- Stigler & Becker 1990: norms provide a stickiness to the status quo; deviating from norms induces an informational cost. (Could be a good jump to Romer/Rosenthal if needed)
- Stinchcombe 1990: “What we want of our institutions of reason is a proper balance between efficient formal approximations that can have a reliable social effect, and

substantive good sense to know their limits and to improve them.”

- Miller 1990: control by means of effective incentive design is contradictory and disproven by social choice; instead, personalistic leadership (i.e., inspiration, interpersonal encouragement) is an optimal approach. Directly tied to Weber 1922’s discussion of charismatic leadership, and directly opposed to the Northian view of institutional supremacy
- Geertz 1973: Interpretivism facilitates a focus on meaning rather than on observable outcomes, particularly wrt cultural phenomena. Anti-rationalist approach, claiming that its focus on rationality without emotions does not allow for complete understanding
- Weber 1904 – discussion of capitalism as rationalism, but cautions against either full rationalization or full spiritualization of the social implications of the protestant ethic
- Helmke & Levitsky: ethnography allows us to support rationalist examinations by more intensely considering actors’ understanding of rules (and thereby differentiate between behavioral regularities and informal institutions)
- Path dependency:
  - Pierson 1997: institutions have increasing returns as they age, and therefore it becomes incredibly difficult or costly to make drastic changes at later points

Specific examples:

- Cox 1997: much of electoral politics happens outside of equilibrium
- Lijphart 1999: (my critique) characterizes a great deal of out-of-equilibrium behavior rather than ultimately proved short lived and ineffective
- Ostrom 1990: rationality and interpretivism can be complementary; namely, qualitative analysis can absolutely be consubstantial with a rational choice framework

## Positive Theory

- Positivism: use of rational logic and empirical reasoning to come to conclusions. Every piece of information is either from first principles or can be justified logically/empirically
- Weber as an antipositivist: move instead towards evaluating broader social phenomena and interactions as being highly humanistic (this is also interpretism)
- See Geertz 1973 “Thick Description” for a modern interpretation of interpretivism
- Clark et al 2017: Models exist to identify patterns through recognizing commonalities across otherwise distinct phenomena
- Diermeier & Krehbiel: structure-induced equilibrium (SIE), whereby institutions “impose sufficient order on collective choice that stable outcomes result.” Became the

basis of “New Institutionalism”

- McKelvey-Schofield chaos theorems: with multidimensional preferences, majority rule is unstable, and a sufficient series of alternatives exists to deliver almost any alternative as the outcome. (Also think Romer-Rosenthal agenda setting here)

Personal note on this – good interpretivist theory should essentially be positive as well, at least insofar as it can be reflected by formal incentive modeling. If we cannot come up with a rational explanation *based on the results of interpretivist reasoning*, then the answer is at the very least incomplete. Yet, this is potentially the greatest present research frontier in many such cases – an explanation does not match a known rational process, which suggests that there must exist some unknown rational process. (Key examples – Ostrom, Stokes et al, maybe Scott 1985. Putnam 1993 of course)

## Foundations of Institutions

- Stinchcombe 1990: “What we want of our institutions of reason is a proper balance between efficient formal approximations that can have a reliable social effect, and substantive good sense to know their limits and to improve them.”
- North 1990a, 1990b: Institutions are “the rules of the game,” “consist of informal constraints and formal rules and of their enforcement characteristics.”
  - Per North – Institutions exist to reduce transaction costs, and the effectiveness of an institution (or series of institutions) can be broadly measured by evaluating its resultant reduction of transaction costs
  - However, also per North 1990b – some institutions seek to raise transaction costs (especially in third world countries)
  - Cites North 1981 – two reasons for institutions producing lesser property rights. First, may pander to certain powerful groups who may otherwise support an alternative ruler/regime. Second, may seek to gain tax revenue (which could be decreased through stronger property rights)
  - North 1990b: “a basic function of institutions is to provide stability and continuity by dampening the effects of relative price changes. It is institutional stability that makes possible complex exchange across space and time.”
- Svobik 2012: autocracies do not enjoy institutional commitment, as the political environment is driven by violence/control rather than by distinct institutional structures. Therefore, institutions in autocracies must be self-supporting such that they are incentive-compatible for those involved (or for those with the power to make changes to them).
- North & Weingast 1989: institutions are most stable when self-enforcing, such that they will persist in equilibrium. (Also see Bois 1999 here – institutional change can be driven by personal desires for utility, as in Krehbiel)

- Penn 2008: Institutions as a collection of weights assigned to various groups, where a weighted median is ultimately enacted
- Helmke & Levitsky: “Informal rules shape how democratic institutions work. They reinforce, subvert, and sometimes even supersede formal rules, procedures, and organizations...” Imperative that we consider “the actual rules that are being followed”. Also has a longer breakdown of formal versus informal institutions
  - There must be some sanction, and that sanction must not simply be a behavioral irregularity: Brinks example that removing a hat in church is an informal institution, but removing a coat in a restaurant is just a behavioral regularity
  - “Informal institutions are widely viewed as obstacles to normatively desirable outcomes, and for good reason. Because they are unwritten and unregulated, informal rules generally lack the transparency or public oversight that is often essential to accountability.”
  - Important to consider the alignment (or lack thereof) between formal and informal institutional outcomes: do the informal institutions produce a similar result?
- Mahoney & Thelen 2009: institutions “stabilize expectations” such that enforcement becomes endogenous: actors consider costs and benefits of noncompliance when deciding on behavioral outcomes
- Shepsle & Bonchek 1997 – importance again of self-reinforcing cooperation as a means by which collective action can be reliably (even if imperfectly) overcome
- Diermeier & Krehbiel: Institutions constrain choices
- Ellickson 1993: informal institutions may be in conflict with formal institutions, and may create separate equilibria: because farmers believe that motorist liability is based on open vs. closed range, they tend to act (and informally settle disputes) on that behalf, even though local law and insurance agencies actually take an opposite approach.
- Milgrom, North, & Weingast 1990: The law merchant. Institutions arise again as a means of reducing risk / transaction costs and facilitating higher levels of exchange. Agreements had to be enforced across time and space as connectivity grew and reputational concerns became less meaningful (i.e., repetition of interactions could not be guaranteed)

## Legislative Principal/Agents

- Cartel theory: parties are weak but legislators are strong; parties effectively cannot control their members (at least in US congress) and so instead must resort to influence and responsiveness
- Legislators face an inherent incentive to prioritize their own voters, but this can be counterproductive for their party – subsequently, a foundational tension exists between

legislators and their party leaders about whether to vote in line or pursue individual goals:

- Diermeier & Vlaicu 2011: collective action problem where legislator can extract personal rents at the expense of party unity
- Jones & Hwang 2005: Cartel theory seems to occur in Argentina
- Kats & Mair 1995: Cartel theory; mass party is a single point in party development and cartels create a near-total overlap between the party and the state
- Crisp et al 2004: Legislators decide whether to focus on local or national issues
- Carey & Shugart 1995: When voters decide to prioritize personal versus party reputation; how this might change across voting systems (big note here: closed list is hard-for-party)
- Cox 1987: How this power cessation to the party occurred (by means of solving an information problem)
- Legislators have multiple principals to whom they are agents (Carey 2009) – the more agents there are, and the more authority they have, and the more their goals conflict, the less effective we should expect legislative outcomes to be.
  - Tsebelis 1999: the more veto players, the less effective we should expect the legislature to be – laws passed will be less significant
- For legislatures as principals, see Huber & Shipan 2002
- Huber & Shipan 2002: legislative capacity – the costs that legislators face to drafting detailed legislation (opportunity, time, etc.)
- Stokes et al 2013 – parties employ brokers to solve informational problems, but these brokers have their own incentives that may be misaligned.
- Clark et al 2017: dissent post-transition can result in either Exit, Voice, or Loyalty; it is the actor's credible threat of departure that facilitates concessions from the central body
- Arrioloa, Devaro, & Meng 2021: Ruling parties can appoint cross-party figures into government roles as a means of fracturing the opposition

## Legislative Accountability & Elections

- Cox 1997: Elections are market activities with a balanced supply and demand of candidates ( $M+1$  rule) BUT can be broken by specifically ethnic or geographic parties, etc. (like SNP)
  - Gibbard-Satterthwaite impossibility: either dictatorship, non-universality, not-strategy-proof, or indecisive



- Arrow impossibility: either dictatorship, or IIA, or non-pareto
- Cox 1997: Three fundamental translations: social cleavages into partisan preferences, partisan preferences into votes, votes into seats
- Lijphart 1999: central bank dependency as a metric of federal vs. unitary systems
- Powell 2000: 2x2 of voters' target of choice (legislator or collective government) and voters' time perspective (retrospective vs. prospective accountability). Majoritarianism should be best in responsiveness; proportionalism should be best in congruence
- Powell 2000: the failures of majoritarianism may be the result of asking elections to do “too much” – represent preferences too holistically, accurately respond to voter sentiments, etc. Presents two frameworks based on whether or not a vote is sufficient to fully express preferences
- Powell 2000: Electoral accountability requires clarity of responsibility – it must be possible to identify who is responsible for what policies. (This is a possible drawback of proportionalism, as assigning blame across a coalition can be difficult)
  - Carey & Shugart 1995 personal vs. party brands, Crisp et al 2004: Candidates have varying incentives to pursue national versus parochial policy efforts
- Fearon 1999: Even though the electorate would like to commit to holding elected officials accountable, in equilibrium their votes will simply reflect perceptions of candidate type. That is, so long as another alternative does not appear to be simply “better,” it becomes very difficult for voters to hold candidates accountable. (Potentially a Cuomo reflection here?)

## Majoritarian vs. Proportionalism

- Boix 1999: ruling parties can use the transition between majoritarianism and PR to maintain some exclusivity (even if possibly conceding contestation)
- Can tie to Ziblatt 2017 – do the elites maintain meaningful political influence as democratization occurs? This is potentially more feasible under proportionalism than majoritarianism
- Huber & Shipan 2002: Autonomy can also be largely influenced by whether or not the governing body has a majority versus a proportional lead: in the case of a majority, where ongoing conflict may be lessened (lesser need to involve the opposition), we can expect to see greater discretion to bureaucrats as they have fewer competing agents and are more trusted by the ruling government
- Lijphart 1999: Core breakdown of majoritarian as government *by* the people but proportionalism as government *for* the people. Characterizes democracies along an executive-parties dimension and a federal-unitary dimension
- Proportionalism protects minorities:

- Lijphart 1999: consensus democracy effective when national cleavages are clear, by lowering the stakes of winning office and protecting minorities
- Lewis 1965: “to exclude the losing groups from participation in decision-making clearly violates the primary meaning of democracy.”
- Abizadeh 2021 – very critical of majoritarianism as it invalidates political equality
- Powell 2000: majoritarianism can construct “mandates to rule,” which are necessarily anti-minority
- Powell 2000 is the foundational work here: majoritarianism as a near-absolute right to rule (and the possibility of a mandate), proportionalism as a metric of relative influence in policymaking
  - Powell – also connected to the strength of the opposition. A meaningful opposition implies some degree of proportionalism; if the opposition has no credible role, it is instead more relegated to a majoritarian system
  - Powell’s mandates: A mandate requires an “identifiable prospective government” and “a responsively formed working majority after the election” – create a simplified, unidimensional policy space allowing for unbounded action by an elected majority
- Powell 2000 – A primary difference in party share of government is balance versus stability. Majoritarianism creates balance on either side of a very sharp cutoff between full inclusion and full exclusion; proportionalism creates more stable transitions along a progressive tradeoff
- See above, and w/ Powell – arguments for proportionalism generally exclude a discussion of how to protect interests at a local level
- Tsebelis 1999: As the number (and dissent) of veto players increases, the legislative capacity of the state decreases; we should also expect to see an increase in pork spending and logrolling to satisfy these individuals
  - Clear tie to Ferejohn 1988 Pork Barrel Politics: broadening democratic participation can require costly expenditures in pork spending, and additional pork is seen distributed towards those with oversight of public works funding
  - Also clear tie to Romer-Rosenthal: incongruence & frequent veto players result in a propensity for status quo reversion at a much higher rate
- Lijphart 1991: Proportionalism more effective, though potentially lower cross-sectional ability to govern. Defines a support for moderate PR whereby some barriers to entry exist (alternative being extreme PR)
- Boix 1999: Systems change with the emergence of new (namely Socialist) parties – if there is no dominant party, expect a shift to PR to protect establishment interests. If there is a dominant party that establishment can coordinate around, however, majoritarianism is likely to be sustained

Note: Westminster as a majoritarian model with power centralized in a cabinet / PM

## Authoritarian Politics

- Repression is costly (Dahl 1972) and accordingly regimes without significant resources may just be more likely to tolerate an active opposition; conversely, if the state is highly endowed, this can raise the stakes of holding office and become a broader issue [cite this specifically? Svobik 2012?](#)
  - Broad-scale oppression does not happen in polyarchies (Dahl 1972) – low barriers to contestation protect inclusivity for marginalized groups and preemptively dissuades additional violence by the state
- Broadly characterized by either traditional or (especially) charismatic leadership a la Weber's tripartite approach to authority
- Svobik 2012: authoritarian institutions must be self-supporting. Deliberative / decision making institutions are particularly helpful, mostly those which provide additional transparency to stakeholders: members of the selectorate must be able to observe actions by the dictators
  - A key factor here: are there credible opponents (after death of Stalin), or is the autocrat well-established (African regimes)?
- Svobik 2012: repression and cooptation are complementary strategies: coopt when possible, repress when necessary. Cooptation is generally a more stable approach if the possibility exists
- Gandhi & Przeworski 2007 – autocrats employ quasi-heterogeneous legislatures to absorb opposition forces and offer some credible power. (A la Powell, this can also be used to justify a mandate to rule, if a legitimate opposition is illegitimately overcome) Employing such legislatures tends to lead to a longer tenure
  - If an authoritarian nation is endowed with significant natural resources, we would expect greater legislative homogeneity, as there is less of a need for the government to coopt citizen groups to extract wealth
- Boix 2003: peace under authoritarianism requires the effective demobilization/disorganization of the lower classes; their organization capacity (and capacity to overcome collective action problems) is central to maintained control
- Boix 2003: elites can either repress or democratize

## Institutional Endogeneity

- Electoral institutions are created by political actors with incentives to maximize their chances of achieving, holding, and executing power (Boix 1999, Lijphart 1991 is a bit softer)

- The choice of electoral institutions tangibly impacts policy outcomes – very similar to above point, with Cox’s applied translations (social cleavages → partisan preferences → votes → seats) – see Cox 1997
- An abundance of resources makes holding power more valuable; Dahl 1972: those with the means to do so will attempt to bend political systems in their favor, but the distribution of those means itself is endogenous. (Also tied to inequality, which can arise in more developed economies)
- Huber & Shipman 2002: bureaucratic institutions chosen based on the trust of the ruling party in bureaucrats to implement their ideal policies
  - Connect to informational asymmetry – Gandhi/Przeworski for autocrats, Ahmed & Stavastange for resource extraction
  - Mahoney & Thelen 2009: “compliance is inherently complicated by the fact that rules can never be precise enough to cover the complexities of all possible real-world situations”
- Huntington 1968: while economic and social development may occur endogenously, political institutionalization requires applied efforts and organization
- Levy 2006: somewhat endogenous? Transition of institutional goals
- Miller 1990: managers look for modes of inducing voluntary cooperation within the Leviathan, particularly given the difficulty of establishing logically consistent incentive structures to do so
- Ostrom 1990: institutions for CPR management are most effective when they are primarily endogenous, such that they are formed, operated by, and consist of those individuals to whom the CPR is relevant to. Self-government as a form of institutional resilience
  - Second-order collective action problem: creating institutions is costly, and so there is an incentive to simply let others make that investment. (Comment – although, in doing so, personal interests may be harder to protect without direct involvement/investment)
- Krehbiel 2004 (cited in Diermeier & Vlaicu 2011): we can treat institutional arrangements as policy preferences themselves, essentially, and so their equilibrium outcomes will also represent the median legislative preferences
- Harmel & Janda 1994: party change results from leadership change, a change in dominant faction, or some external stimulus.
- Boix 1999: Electoral systems are designed partially by the parties in power, who want to further alter the rules to maximize their own goals. Electoral systems often change with the emergence of new (especially Socialist) parties
- Weber 1904: once capitalism becomes self-sustaining, the religious justifications are not necessary

- Helmke & Levitsky: Accommodating informal institutions may make formal institutions more resilient and less necessary to change, as the negative effects of those formal institutions can be reduced
- Mahoney & Thelen 2009: Institutions affect resource distribution, and many formal institutions are accordingly designed to distribute resources to specific groups and not others: “This is true for precisely those institutions that mobilize significant and highly valued resources (e.g., most political and political-economic institutions).”
- Diermeier & Krehbiel 2003: Institutionalism as a methodology more so than a chaotic substantive problem: “The necessarily partial endogenization of institutional features is what distinguishes an institutional theory from a theory of institutions.”
  - Perhaps the biggest contribution to institutionalism as a methodology. Theory of institutions assumes that institutions are exogenous, but institutionalism admits that the construction of those institutions are themselves endogenous, as well as the institutions which constructed those institutions, as well as the institutions which constructed those institutions... “turtles all the way down”
- Ellickson 1993: when informal institutions conflict with formal institutions, they may impact the ability of those formal institutions to develop or even be enacted in the first place. Behavior does not always represent formal institutions simply because they are formal. Also poses an informational problem
- Carrubba 2009: courts at first are limited to their specific charter, but as they gain legitimacy, its enforcement capabilities (and breadth) expand
- Pierson 1997: institutions have increasing returns as they age, and therefore it becomes incredibly difficult or costly to make drastic changes at later points
- Selznick 1949 – institutions must essentially coopt local institutions where possible to ensure good governance. Institutions must adapt to their environments

## Patronage & Targeted Benefits

- Stokes et al 2013: Core breakdown of distributive politics, including a complete definition set. Core issues include whether or not the rules are public, whether the intent is to influence vs. hold to account, and exactly how targeted the benefits are
  - Clientelism creates an informational problem – it is incredibly difficult to know exactly what specific voters need/want, and whether or not they act in accordance with the party’s wishes if their needs are met
  - Claim: swing voters should be predicted to receive a disproportionate degree of targeted benefits, but we instead see a great amount of benefits go towards solid supporters.
    - \* Nichter 2008 answers this and claims that it is instead an effort to buy “turnout” from consistently supportive-leaning voters rather than to buy

turnout *and* support from consistently swing voters

- \* Also Nichter: it is easier to monitor turnout than specific votes; the driving mechanism of turnout buying versus vote buying is the informational cost and monitoring difficulty of monitoring individual vote outcomes rather than turnout
- Crisp et al 2004: Some legislators seek to provide broadly public goods (i.e., national policies) while others seek to provide targeted goods (parochial) – ties to Pork, etc.
- Schmitter 1974: Corporatism as a non-competitive form of patronage-ish – state and regulatory capture. Corporatism is a distinct alternative to pluralistic models of interest politics, in that the state itself is coopted by the interest group(s)

## Presidential vs Parliamentary

- Jones & Hwang 2005: impact of presidentialism is that individual legislators have significant more control over their own career futures, and accordingly are more likely to build a personalized brand. Cartel theory suggests that legislators are individually responsible
  - Carey & Shugart 1995 (local vs. national issues), Crisp et al 2004: Candidates have varying incentives to promote personal brands versus attach to their party's brands
  - J&H also show that Cartel theory may extend beyond the US, in particular that it seems to be applicable in ARgentinian politics
  - Harmel & Janda 1994 – may be a note on opposition here
- Cheibub et al 2004: coalitions are found in presidential systems even when the president's leadership is in the minority. Central differentiating fact: a president cannot be immediately removed by a hostile legislative majority, whereas a prime minister can be. However, a minority president may become legislatively incapacitated (see Tsebelis 1999 for discussion of this as a metric of democratic quality). Key issue: is the president agenda-setting or a veto player?
- Carey & Shugart 1995: closed list does not support personal-brand-building
- Lijphart 1991: Strongly supports parliamentarianism and PR for new democracies

## Bureaucracy

- Huber & Shipman 2002 – all of deliberate discretion. Discretion to bureaucratic agencies is a function of the trust the ruling party has in its bureaucratic agents and the level of conflict/competition in place from other parties. Also note: “Wise and salutary neglect” as a quote from Edmund Burke 1775

- Informational asymmetry forms the basis of much of this discretion (Huber & Shipman 2002) – bureaucrats often have better information / more expertise than legislators, but also may have misaligned incentives
- Ahmend & Stasavage 2020: one historical basis for the formation of bureaucracies was to evaluate productivity variation resulting from informational asymmetries of resource extraction – that is, the leader could not perfectly know the best way to extract, but the bureaucracy could provide valuable information to further this
- Dasgupta & Kapur 2020: Discussion of bureaucratic overload, and suggests that insufficient resources may be expected where responsibility for policy implementation is unclear: politicians under-invest when there is a lack of electoral incentives in that region

## State Capacity

- General model of development in Huntington 1968
- Ziblatt 2017 – capacity to involve the elites while still expanding the franchise?
- Ostrom 1990 – is there enough social capital to make endogenous institutions effective? (Very much in line with Putnam here as well)
- Huber & Shipman 2002 – state capacity ultimately impacts how politicians will organize bureaucratic orders. Also, state capacity may be modeled as the costs that the state faces to governing (maybe this can be better viewed as efficiency?)
- Huntington 1968 (the whole thing, pretty much)
- Another point of state capacity: the political institutions must have the capacity to handle the involvement of all those who are part of the political sphere. If there is not sufficient institutional / state capacity to handle this, we should expect to see extrainstitutional (and often violent) alternatives
- Levy 2006: state capacity hasn't decreased, it's just shifted to alternative activities
- Iversen & Soskice 2019: state capacity facilitates efficient markets (and state capacity is driven by broad participation of relevant actors)
- Kalyvas 2006: indiscriminate violence more likely when control over a region is minimal
- Hardin 1990: Gunman theory of law – enforcement purely by means of fear / violence is unachievable and inadequate

## Other assorted factors (and where to find them)

- Trust: Dahl 1972, mechanized through commitment devices by A&R, N&W, and within authoritarian states by Gandhi & Przeworski 2007. Kalyvas 2006: indiscrimi-

nate violence destroys trust between regime and supporters and is subsequently counterproductive

## **Key Divides**

### **Democracy & Economic Development**

Does democracy cause economic development, or does economic development prime democracy?

### **Strength of Parties**

Do parties matter? Are they driving organizations, or responsive?

### **Rationalism & Interpretivism**

Which (if any) are effective, and which is best?

### **Institutional Definitions**

Rules of the game vs. tangible structures...?

### **Structures vs. Norms**

Which are the most appropriate representation of institutions?

### **Formats of Democracy**

Majoritarianism vs. Proportionalism; Presidentialism vs. Parliamentaryism

### **Definitions of Democracy**

- Tsebelis 1999: Democratic durability is tied to an ability to pass significant laws
- Przeworski et al: a system where parties lose
- General framework – contestation. Question: is it that contestation is possible, or present?
- Boix 1993: “property is preserved and everybody votes on the tax rate.”

### **Salience of Identity**

see note to self